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UAE revises law on sugary drink taxes

NEW TIERED SYSTEM ON BEVERAGES
TO TAKE EFFECT ON JANUARY 1, 2026

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The UAE Ministry of Finance confirmed that new updates to the country's excise tax law on sugary drinks will take effect on January 1, 2026. The update is meant to make the tax system more efficient and aligned with new standards set by the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).

"The UAE Ministry of Finance has announced the completion of a set of proposed legislative amendments to embed the updated excise tax policy into the national legislation," the ministry said yesterday.

"This step is in line with the GCC's adoption of a tiered volumetric model for excise tax on sugar-sweetened beverages (SSBs). The amendments aim to establish a comprehensive legal and regulatory foundation that ensures the smooth implementation of the updated policy at the national level, with effect from January 1, 2026."

Under the changes, the UAE will move from a flat 50 per cent tax on all sugar-sweetened drinks to a tiered system, where the amount of tax depends on how much sugar or sweetener a drink contains. This new approach is part of the GCC's regional model for taxing sugar-sweetened beverages.

Under the changes, the UAE will move from a flat 50% tax on all sugar-sweetened drinks to a tiered system, where the amount of tax depends on how much sugar or sweetener a drink contains.

The new tiered model means drinks with more sugar will face higher taxes, while those with less sugar will be taxed at lower rates. This method aims to encourage drink makers to reduce sugar levels in their products and give consumers more options to choose healthier drinks.

Global best practices

The Ministry said the amendments also include a rule for importers and producers who have already paid the current 50 per cent excise tax on goods before the new system starts. If their tax rate is lower under the new model and the goods have not been sold, they can deduct part of the previously paid tax.

The Ministry explained that the changes are part of efforts to keep the UAE's tax system in line with global best practices and GCC regulations. The goal is to make the system fair, flexible, and easier to manage for both businesses and government authorities.



ONE DEAD, HUNDREDS TRAPPED BY SNOW NEAR EVEREST

Rescuers in Tibet are helping hikers trapped by heavy snow near Mount Everest, where one person has died and hundreds have been brought to safety. A young trekker, FeiFei, told AFP that she and her group were camping in the Karma Valley, at nearly 5,000 metres, when overnight snowfall buried their tents. Authorities said 350 hikers had been rescued, but more than 200 remain stranded in high-altitude camps as operations continue.

2 years on, Gaza talks rekindle hope

Sharm Al Shaikh talks aim for truce, hostage swap

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

As the war in Gaza enters its third year, Israeli and Hamas officials began indirect peace talks in Egypt yesterday, raising hopes of ending a conflict that has devastated the enclave and killed over 67,100 Palestinians.

The talks in Sharm Al Shaikh, mediated by Egypt and backed by the United States, aim to secure a ceasefire, a par-

tial withdrawal of Israeli forces, and the exchange of hostages for Palestinian prisoners.

Hamas said it has accepted parts of the US peace plan, which calls for the release of the remaining 48 hostages — around 20 believed alive — within three days and for Hamas to disarm and cede power.

Gaza reduced to ruins

Since the war began on October 7, 2023, after Hamas fighters breached Israel's border, killing 1,200 people and taking 251 hostages, Gaza has been reduced to ruins. The UN has described Israel's campaign as a "genocide," citing the destruction of 90% of

homes, 1.9 million displaced, and widespread famine that has claimed hundreds of lives.

Two years on, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has yet to achieve his goals of destroying Hamas and recovering all hostages, but the talks in Egypt mark the first glimmer of diplomacy amid relentless war.

However, uncertainties remain about the plan presented by US President Donald Trump last week, including the disarmament of Hamas and the future governance of Gaza. Trump has indicated an agreement on Gaza could pave the way for a Middle East peace process that could reshape the region.

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Diwali sweet boom: Dubai stores race to keep up with Dh400/kg demand

Festive rush sees shoppers splurge on premium sweets and gifts

DUBAI
BY SURABHI VASUNDHARADEVI
Social Media Reporter

As Diwali draws near, Dubai's sweet shops are buzzing like never before. The festive season has sparked a 300 per cent jump in demand for traditional Indian delicacies — many stores are suspending dine-in services days ahead just to focus on fulfilling orders.

What's flying off shelves? Classic treats like boondi, besan laddoos, and pista badam burfi now fetch between Dh80 and Dh400 per kg, with prices varying by ingredients and quality. Some shops go premium — dry fruit varieties command Dh150 to Dh380 per kg.

Gift hampers are the other big winner. Starting at Dh200, these wooden boxes packed with sweets and nuts run as high as

Dh650, made bespoke to match customer budgets.

Famous names like Purnanmal, Bikanerwala, Govindas, and Shree Gangour Sweets are feeling the pressure. Many have shut down dining areas for days to devote their staff to packaging and delivery.

Behind the surge is the UAE's deep Indian expat community. For many, Diwali without sweets doesn't feel complete — whether for homes, offices, or clients. Some buyers, though, are mixing in healthier options like nuts and savoury snacks to balance tradition with wellness.

This year, sweets aren't just treats — they've become a statement, a way to celebrate culture, share gratitude, and bridge communities in Dubai's colourful festival season.

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